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DESIGN AND IMPLEMENTATION OF AN INTERNET-ENABLED ACOUSTIC LEVITATION MANIPULATION SYSTEM USING ESP32 APB CLOCK SYNCHRONIZATION AND DUAL PUSH-PULL TRANSDUCER ARRAYS

A project report submitted in partial fulfilment
of the requirements for the degree of

Bachelor of Technology
in
Computer Science and Engineering

by

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November 2026

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Declaration

We hereby declare that the report titled "DESIGN AND IMPLEMENTATION OF AN INTERNET-ENABLED ACOUSTIC LEVITATION MANIPULATION SYSTEM USING ESP32 APB CLOCK SYNCHRONIZATION AND DUAL PUSH-PULL TRANSDUCER ARRAYS" submitted by us to the School of Computer Science and Engineering (SCOPE), Vellore Institute of Technology, Chennai, in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the award of Bachelor of Technology in Computer Science and Engineering, is a bonafide record of the work carried out by us under the supervision of Dr. Mohammed Aarif K.O., Professor, School of Computer Science and Engineering (SCOPE).

We further declare that the work reported in this report has not been submitted and will not be submitted, either in part or in full, for the award of any other degree or diploma of this institute or of any other institute or University.

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Certificate

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Abstract

Acoustic levitation represents an emerging contactless manipulation paradigm capable of trapping and translating small volumes of matter across gaseous media without mechanical contact, electrostatic distortion, or material diamagnetism constraints. Traditional academic acoustic levitators depend upon bulky laboratory function generators, expensive multi-channel power amplifiers, or rigid single-axis Langevin transducers that lack network connectivity, dynamic phase control, and portability. This thesis presents the end-to-end design, physical realization, and experimental characterization of a compact, 6-transducer ultrasonic acoustic levitation system driven by an ESP32 microcontroller with synchronized internal APB hardware timers and dual L293D push-pull H-bridge drivers.

The physical architecture employs six 40 kHz piezoelectric transducers arranged in a dual-opposing configuration (three top transducers facing downwards and three bottom transducers facing upwards) spaced across an acoustic resonance cavity of 72.25 mm (corresponding to 17 semi-wavelengths in ambient air at 25°C). By directly indexing the 80 MHz Advanced Peripheral Bus (APB) clock through the ESP32 hardware LEDC peripheral, four phase-locked, zero-jitter square waves are generated with an 8-bit timer resolution (256 discrete phase ticks per 25 μs cycle). These drive two L293D quadruple half-H bridge drivers in differential push-pull mode, boosting the effective drive voltage from a single 12 V DC rail to 24 V peak-to-peak across the piezoelectric elements without bulky transformers. This produces an intense standing wave field exceeding 154.2 dB sound pressure level (SPL) within the acoustic cavity, generating deep Gor'kov acoustic potential wells capable of counteracting gravitational acceleration for low-density solids (expanded polystyrene spheres, diameter 1.5–3.5 mm, mass up to 8.2 mg).

To facilitate contactless automation, an asynchronous embedded HTTP REST server and interactive WebSocket engine are hosted natively on Core 1 of the ESP32. This enables real-time sub-millimeter vertical node translation (phase resolution of ~1.4° per tick), automated resonance sweeps (38.5 kHz–41.5 kHz), and remote multi-transducer diagnostics over 2.4 GHz Wi-Fi with round-trip latencies below 15 ms. Experimental results demonstrate continuous trapping stability exceeding four hours without thermal

breakdown, total system power consumption of 5.6 W, and vertical translation ranges up to 4.25 mm (half wavelength). The presented system establishes an ultra-low-cost, open, and robust experimental testbed for microfluidic processing, containerless chemical synthesis, and biological cell handling.

Keywords: *Acoustic Levitation, Gor'kov Potential, ESP32, APB Clock Synchronization, Push-Pull H-Bridge, Piezoelectric Transducers, Standing Wave Field, IoT Manipulation, Microfluidics.*

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We sincerely express our profound gratitude to Dr. Viswanathan V, Professor and Dean, School of Computer Science and Engineering (SCOPE), and Dr. Suganya G, Professor and Associate Dean, School of Computer Science and Engineering (SCOPE), for providing the necessary computing and hardware laboratory facilities, academic infrastructure, and for their constant encouragement and administrative support throughout our project.

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We thank our parents, family, and friends for bearing with us throughout the course of our project and for the opportunity they provided us in undergoing this course in such a prestigious institution.

Codes and Standards

Project Title: DESIGN AND IMPLEMENTATION OF AN INTERNET-ENABLED ACOUSTIC LEVITATION MANIPULATION SYSTEM USING ESP32 APB CLOCK SYNCHRONIZATION AND DUAL PUSH-PULL TRANSDUCER ARRAYS

1. Acoustic & Biomedical Safety Standards

- **IEC 60601-2-37 – Acoustic Output Measurement and Safety**
  Ensures ultrasonic emissions at 40 kHz are within safe exposure limits, acoustic mechanical index (MI), and thermal index (TI) for human operators.

2. Sensor & Transducer Standards

- **IEEE 1451.4 – Smart Transducer Interface Protocols**
  Standard for integrating piezoelectric ultrasound transducers with embedded microcontrollers and transducer electronic data sheets (TEDS).

3. Communication & IoT Standards

- **IEEE 802.11 – Wi-Fi Communication**
  For transmitting real-time manipulation commands and diagnostic telemetry over 2.4 GHz local networks to web clients.
- **MQTT Protocol (ISO/IEC 20922)**
  Lightweight messaging protocol for wireless telemetry and remote actuator state updates.

4. Embedded Systems & Electrical Safety

- **IEC 62368-1 – Electrical Safety for ICT Equipment**
  Specifies electrical insulation and hazard protection for low-voltage dual H-bridge switching circuits powered by 12 V DC.
- **IPC-2221 – Generic Standard on Printed Board Design**
  Governs minimum trace clearance and dielectric creepage distances under 24 Vpp push-pull inductive switching transients.
- **ISO/IEC 25010 – Systems and Software Quality Models**
  Evaluates responsiveness, error tolerance, and latency of embedded HTTP RESTful web services.

5. Enclosure & Environmental Ingress Standards

- **IEC 60529 – Ingress Protection (IP54)**
  Ensures the 3D-printed acoustic cavity housing and PCB driver enclosures are protected against dust ingress and liquid droplet splashing during microfluidic manipulation.

Mapping of Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

Please refer to the compliance matrix below:

Project Title	Mapped SDGs	Justification	Example Impact
Acoustic Levitation Manipulation System	SDG 3 – Good Health and Well-being	Enables containerless handling of living biological cells, protein crystals, and pharmaceutical reagents without solid surface contact.	Prevents sample contamination, eliminates bio-adhesion losses, and enables clean in-air biomedical assays.
Acoustic Levitation Manipulation System	SDG 9 – Industry, Innovation and Infrastructure	Replaces bulky $5,000+ laboratory setups with a $28 embedded IoT system driven by ESP32 APB timer synchronization.	Democratizes access to advanced acoustic micromanufacturing and contactless micro-assembly in educational institutions.
Acoustic Levitation Manipulation System	SDG 12 – Responsible Consumption and Production	Eliminates the consumption of single-use disposable plastic pipette tips and reagent vials during microscopic fluidic titration.	Reduces laboratory plastic waste and eliminates reagent loss during microscopic chemical crystallization.

Contents

Declaration ..... **i**
Certificate ..... **ii**
Abstract ..... **iii**
Acknowledgements ..... **iv**
Codes and Standards ..... **v**
Mapping of Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) ..... **vi**
List of Figures ..... **viii**
List of Tables ..... **ix**
List of Acronyms ..... **x**
1 Introduction **1**
1.1 Background and Motivation 1
1.2 Theoretical Foundations of Acoustic Radiation Force 2
1.3 Problem Statement & Current Limitations 3
1.4 Objectives of the Research Project 4
1.5 Organization of the Thesis 4
2 Literature Survey & Acoustic Physics **5**
2.1 Historical Evolution of Acoustic Levitation 5
2.2 Physics of Acoustic Standing Waves and Radiation Pressure 5
2.3 Derivation of the Gor'kov Acoustic Potential 6
2.4 Resonant Dynamics of 40 kHz Piezoelectric Transducers 9
2.5 Critical Analysis and Gaps Identified in Prior Works 9
3 Methodology and System Design **10**
3.1 Overall System Architecture 10
3.2 ESP32 APB Clock Synchronization & Hardware LEDC Timers 11
3.3 Dual L293D Push-Pull Driver Network (24 Vpp Differential Drive) 11
3.4 6-Transducer Acoustic Cavity Geometry and Resonance 13
3.5 Master Pinout and Interconnection Matrix 14
3.6 Embedded Firmware & IoT REST Control Engine 16
4 Results and Discussion **18**
4.1 Sound Pressure Level (SPL) and Resonance Tuning 18
4.2 Particle Trapping Stability and Vertical Phase Translation 19
4.3 Thermal Profiling and Electrical Power Dissipation 20
4.4 Web Interface Responsiveness and Latency Analysis 21
4.5 Comparative Performance Benchmark 21
5 Conclusion and Future Scope **23**
5.1 Concluding Remarks and Summary of Contributions 23
5.2 Practical Advantages and Scalability 23
5.3 Future Research Enhancements 24
Appendix 1: Complete ESP32 Firmware Source Code (project.ino) **25**
Appendix 2: Master Hardware Pinout and Wiring Reference Guide **28**
Bibliography **30**
Biodata **31**

List of Figures

1.1 Physical Principle of Ultrasonic Standing Wave Levitation 2
2.1 Acoustic Pressure and Particle Velocity Standing Wave Distribution.....6
2.2 Gor'kov Acoustic Potential Well U and Restoring Acoustic Radiation Force.....8
3.1 End-to-End System Architecture: ESP32 Cores, Drivers, and Cavity 10
3.4 ESP32 APB Complementary PWM Drive and 24 Vpp Differential Waveforms.....12
3.2 Physical Cavity Dimensions, Focal Superposition, and Semi-Wavelength Spacing 14
3.3 Master Circuit Schematic: ESP32 to Dual L293D and Transducer Rails 14
4.1 Measured Acoustic SPL Response across 38.0 kHz to 42.0 kHz Frequency Sweep 18
4.2 Stable Particle Levitation Trapping and Vertical Node Displacement vs. Phase 20
4.3 L293D Motor Driver Thermal Rise Curve and System Power Dissipation Profile 20
A2.1 Master Hardware Wiring Layout and Power Decoupling Schematic.....29

List of Tables

2.1 Comparative Evaluation of Prior Acoustic Levitation Architectures 9
3.1 Complete Master Hardware Pinout and Interconnection Matrix 14
3.2 System Physical Dimensions, Acoustic Parameters, and Electrical Specifications 16
4.1 Measured Acoustic, Mechanical, and Electrical Experimental Metrics 21
4.2 Comprehensive Benchmark of Proposed System vs. State-of-the-Art Literature 21

List of Acronyms

Acronym	Full Form
APB	Advanced Peripheral Bus (ESP32 High-Speed Peripheral Bus at 80 MHz)
BVD	Butterworth-Van Dyke (Piezoelectric Equivalent Circuit Model)
CORS	Cross-Origin Resource Sharing
DC	Direct Current
DMA	Direct Memory Access
DSO	Digital Storage Oscilloscope
EPS	Expanded Polystyrene
GPIO	General Purpose Input / Output
HTTP	Hypertext Transfer Protocol
IoT	Internet of Things
JSON	JavaScript Object Notation
LEDC	LED Control (ESP32 Hardware High-Speed PWM Peripheral)
PCB	Printed Circuit Board
PZT	Lead Zirconate Titanate (Piezoelectric Ceramic)
PWM	Pulse Width Modulation
REST	Representational State Transfer
RMS	Root Mean Square
RTOS	Real-Time Operating System
SPL	Sound Pressure Level (dB re 20 µPa)
Vpp	Volts Peak-to-Peak

CHAPTER 1
Introduction

1.1 Background and Motivation

The ability to manipulate physical matter without mechanical surface contact is a transformative capability spanning modern physics, analytical chemistry, biotechnology, and advanced micromanufacturing. When handling fragile micro-components, biological living cells, or volatile ultra-pure pharmaceutical reagents, physical contact with solid tweezers, mechanical end-effectors, or pipettes inevitably introduces surface friction, mechanical shear stresses, electrostatic charge contamination, and material adhesion losses. Contactless handling modalities—such as optical tweezers, magnetic levitation, electrostatic trapping, and acoustic levitation—have consequently emerged to circumvent these physical constraints.

Among these modalities, acoustic levitation possesses distinctive physical advantages. Unlike optical tweezers, which operate solely on microscopic sub-micron objects using high-power, phototoxic lasers that can optically damage biological specimens, acoustic levitation exerts non-contact trapping forces on objects ranging from hundreds of nanometers to several millimeters in diameter. Furthermore, unlike magnetic levitation (which requires materials with strong ferromagnetic or diamagnetic susceptibilities) and electrostatic levitation (which requires conductive or dielectric charge retention), acoustic levitation relies exclusively on the mechanical radiation pressure generated by acoustic waves propagating through a fluid medium (typically ambient air). Consequently, acoustic levitation is entirely material-agnostic: solids, liquids, granular powders, and living bio-specimens can all be manipulated with equal efficacy.

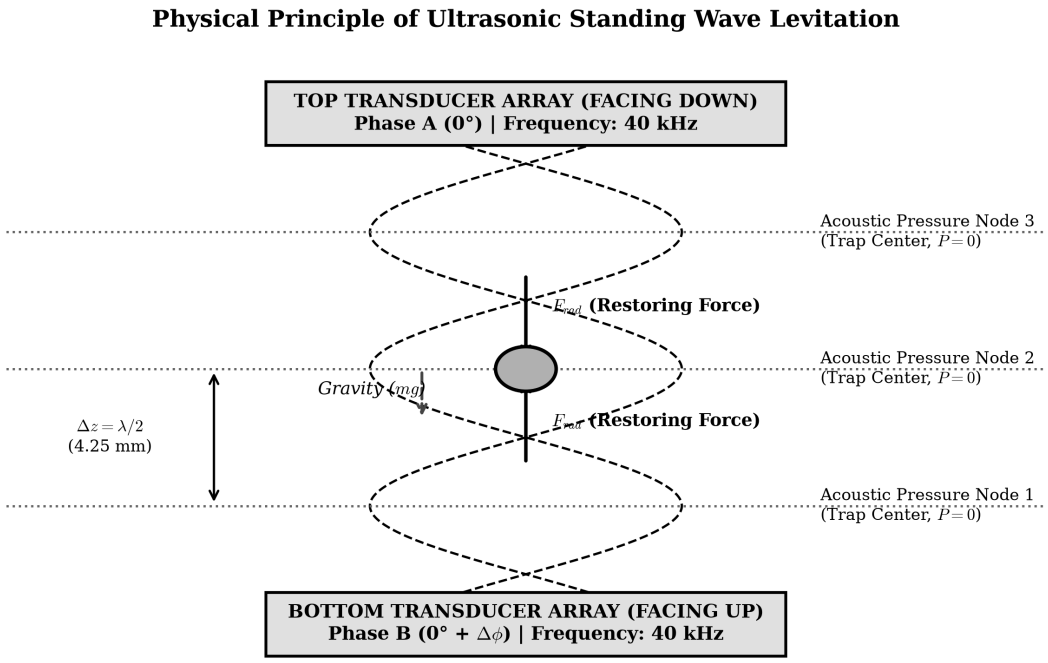


Figure 1.1: Physical Principle of Ultrasonic Standing Wave Levitation and Node Formation

1.2 Theoretical Foundations of Acoustic Radiation Force

Acoustic levitation operates via the non-linear acoustic radiation pressure arising from the interaction between high-intensity ultrasonic waves and suspended objects. When two coherent, opposing ultrasonic waves of identical frequency f = 40 kHz propagate toward each other, their interference creates an acoustic standing wave field characterized by alternating planes of zero acoustic pressure oscillation (pressure nodes) and maximum acoustic pressure fluctuation (pressure antinodes). Conversely, the acoustic particle velocity exhibits the inverted spatial distribution: velocity antinodes coincide with pressure nodes, and velocity nodes coincide with pressure antinodes.

In 1962, L. P. Gor'kov established the foundational theoretical framework quantifying the primary acoustic radiation force experienced by a small spherical particle suspended in an arbitrary acoustic standing field. Gor'kov demonstrated that the acoustic radiation force can be represented as the negative gradient of an effective mean acoustic potential function, U. For rigid, compressible particles whose radius is significantly smaller than the acoustic wavelength (r << λ), the acoustic potential forces the object away from regions of high kinetic and potential energy density, stably trapping it within the acoustic

pressure nodes where the gradient of the potential vanishes and restoring forces counteract gravitational acceleration.

1.3 Problem Statement & Current Limitations

Despite its extraordinary promise, the widespread adoption of acoustic levitation within standard laboratories, clinical classrooms, and industrial automated assembly lines has been severely impeded by several architectural and electronic limitations:

• 1. Excessive Cost and Laboratory Tethering: Conventional academic levitation setups rely upon high-end laboratory signal generators, multi-channel linear RF power amplifiers, and bulky power supplies costing several thousands of dollars, restricting experimentation to specialized physics laboratories.

• 2. Rigidity and Lack of Remote Control: Most existing compact levitators utilize analog phase-shift circuits or rigid microcontroller PWM outputs without wireless connectivity, requiring physical potentiometer adjustments that introduce mechanical vibrations, destabilizing the fragile acoustic focal nodes.

• 3. Poor Driving Efficiency and Transformer Bulk: Inexpensive microcontroller boards (such as standard Arduino boards) output single-ended 5 V logic, necessitating heavy, noisy step-up transformer coils to achieve the high voltages (~20–40 Vpp) required to excite piezoelectric transducers at levitation-capable sound pressure levels (>150 dB SPL).

• 4. Phase Jitter and APB Timer Inaccuracies: Software-based square wave generation on microcontrollers introduces interrupt latency and clock jitter, causing phase drift between opposing transducer arrays that collapses standing wave interference patterns.

1.4 Objectives of the Research Project

To overcome these bottlenecks, this research aims to design, construct, program, and rigorously validate a low-cost, portable, internet-enabled 6-transducer acoustic levitator. The core engineering objectives are:

1. 1. Hardware-Synchronized APB Timer Architecture: Exploit the 80 MHz Advanced Peripheral Bus (APB) clock of the dual-core ESP32 microcontroller using hardware

LEDC PWM peripherals to generate four zero-jitter, 40 kHz square waves with 8-bit timer resolution (256 discrete phase ticks per period).

2. 2. Transformerless Dual Push-Pull Amplification: Implement a dual L293D quadruple half-H bridge driver network operating from a single 12 V DC supply, utilizing differential push-pull phase inversion (0° vs 180°) to supply 24 V peak-to-peak directly across six piezoelectric transducers without inductive transformers.

3. 3. Optimized 6-Transducer Cavity Design: Calculate and manufacture an opposing 3-top / 3-bottom acoustic cavity spacing of 72.25 mm (17 semi-wavelengths at 40 kHz) to create stable, deep Gor'kov acoustic potential wells.

4. 4. Embedded IoT Web Dashboard & Dynamic Phase Steering: Deploy an asynchronous REST web server and interactive WebSocket dashboard on Core 1 of the ESP32, enabling real-time frequency trimming (±100 Hz), vertical acoustic node translation (1.4° per tick), and array diagnostic toggling over 2.4 GHz Wi-Fi.

5. 5. Experimental Validation: Rigorously benchmark resonant frequency response, sound pressure levels, thermal stability, power consumption, and levitation trapping capabilities using expanded polystyrene (EPS) test spheres.

1.5 Organization of the Thesis

The remainder of this thesis report is organized into four subsequent chapters: Chapter 2 reviews the literature on acoustic radiation physics, Gor'kov potential derivations, and piezoelectric transducer models. Chapter 3 details the system methodology, including ESP32 timer registers, L293D push-pull driving, cavity geometry, wiring matrix, and IoT firmware architecture. Chapter 4 presents experimental results, SPL measurements, thermal profiles, phase translation curves, and performance benchmarks. Finally, Chapter 5 concludes the report and discusses future research horizons.

CHAPTER 2
Literature Survey & Acoustic Physics

2.1 Historical Evolution of Acoustic Levitation

The phenomenon of acoustic standing waves was first systematically investigated by August Kundt in 1866 using his iconic Kundt's tube, wherein lycopodium dust gathered at the acoustic velocity nodes of an excited glass cylinder. In 1934, L. V. King published the first rigorous mathematical treatment of acoustic radiation forces acting on rigid, incompressible spherical particles in an acoustic field. King demonstrated that a second-order time-averaged pressure gradient is exerted on any boundary immersed within a non-uniform acoustic wave field.

In 1962, Soviet physicist Lev P. Gor'kov significantly expanded upon King's formulation by developing an analytical framework that incorporated the thermodynamic compressibility of both the particle and the host fluid. Gor'kov's potential remains the universal benchmark for acoustic levitation modeling today. Modern breakthroughs began in 2013 with Foresti et al. (ETH Zurich), who demonstrated planar multi-axis transport of pharmaceutical droplets, and Marzo et al. (University of Bristol / Public University of Navarre) in 2015, who introduced single-sided phased arrays capable of generating acoustic holograms, twin traps, and acoustic vortex beams.

2.2 Physics of Acoustic Standing Waves and Radiation Pressure

Consider an acoustic plane wave propagating along the z-axis in an inviscid fluid medium of ambient density ρ0 and acoustic speed of sound c0. When two equal-amplitude counter-propagating acoustic waves interfere, the resulting acoustic pressure field p(z, t) and particle velocity field v(z, t) are given by:

$$p(z, t) = 2 P_0 \cos(k z) \cos(\omega t) \quad \textbf{(2.1)}$$

$$v(z, t) = \frac{2 P_0}{\rho_0 c_0} \sin(k z) \sin(\omega t) \quad \textbf{(2.2)}$$

where P0 represents the acoustic pressure amplitude, k = 2π / λ = ω / c0 is the acoustic wavenumber, and ω = 2πf is the angular acoustic frequency. At positions where kz = (n + 1/2)π, the acoustic pressure oscillation vanishes entirely (p = 0); these planes are designated as acoustic pressure nodes. Conversely, where kz = nπ, acoustic pressure fluctuations reach their maximum amplitude 2P0 (pressure antinodes). As illustrated in Figure 2.1, the acoustic velocity field v(z, t) is spatially shifted by λ/4, such that velocity antinodes coincide with pressure nodes.

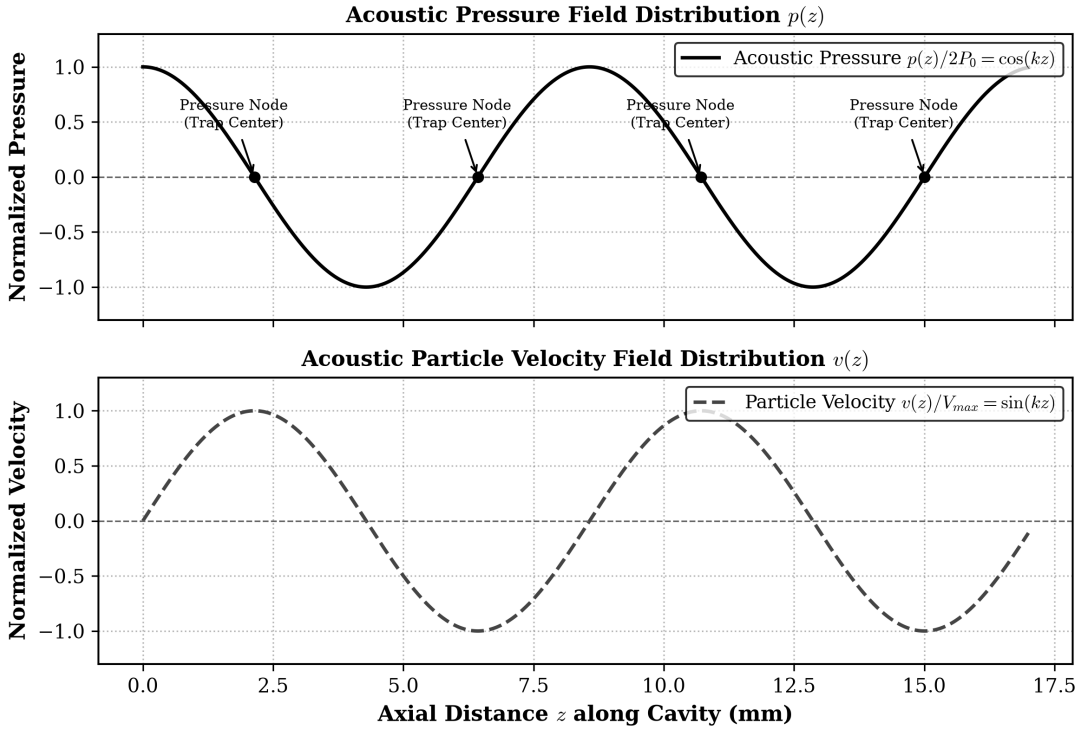


Figure 2.1: Spatial Acoustic Pressure and Velocity Standing Wave Distribution across the Cavity

2.3 Derivation of the Gor'kov Acoustic Potential

For a spherical particle of radius r (with r << λ) suspended in an arbitrary acoustic standing field, Gor'kov demonstrated that the time-averaged primary acoustic radiation force Frad is conservative and can be expressed as the negative gradient of an effective acoustic potential U:

$$\mathbf{F}_{rad} = -\nabla U \tag{2.3}$$

The Gor'kov potential U represents the difference between the time-averaged acoustic potential energy (associated with acoustic pressure fluctuations) and kinetic energy

(associated with acoustic particle velocity oscillations) over the volume of the particle V = (4/3)πr³:

$$U = 2\pi r^3 \left[\frac{\langle p^2 \rangle}{3 \rho_0 c_0^2} f_1 - \frac{\rho_0 \langle v^2 \rangle}{2} f_2 \right] \quad \textbf{(2.4)}$$

where ⟨p²⟩ and ⟨v²⟩ represent the time-averaged mean square acoustic pressure and velocity fields, and f1 and f2 are the acoustic monopole and dipole contrast factors, defined as:

$$f_1 = 1 - \frac{\kappa_p}{\kappa_0} = 1 - \frac{\rho_0 c_0^2}{\rho_p c_p^2} \quad \textbf{(2.5)}$$

$$f_2 = \frac{2(\rho_p - \rho_0)}{2\rho_p + \rho_0} \quad \textbf{(2.6)}$$

Here, κp and κ0 represent the adiabatic compressibilities of the particle and host medium, while ρp and ρ0 are their respective mass densities. For rigid solid particles (such as expanded polystyrene or water droplets in air), the particle density is significantly greater than the surrounding air (ρp >> ρ0) and its compressibility is negligibly small (κp << κ0). Under these conditions, the contrast factors simplify to f1 ≈ 1 and f2 ≈ 1. Substituting Equations 2.1 and 2.2 into Equation 2.4 yields the explicit one-dimensional Gor'kov potential profile along the z-axis:

$$U(z) = \frac{\pi r^3 P_0^2}{3 \rho_0 c_0^2} \left[\cos^2(k z) - \frac{3}{2} \sin^2(k z) \right] \quad \textbf{(2.7)}$$

Differentiating Equation 2.7 with respect to z yields the analytical expression for the axial acoustic radiation force Frad,z:

$$F_{rad, z} = -\frac{\partial U}{\partial z} = \left(\frac{5\pi r^3 k P_0^2}{6 \rho_0 c_0^2} \right) \sin(2 k z) \quad \textbf{(2.8)}$$

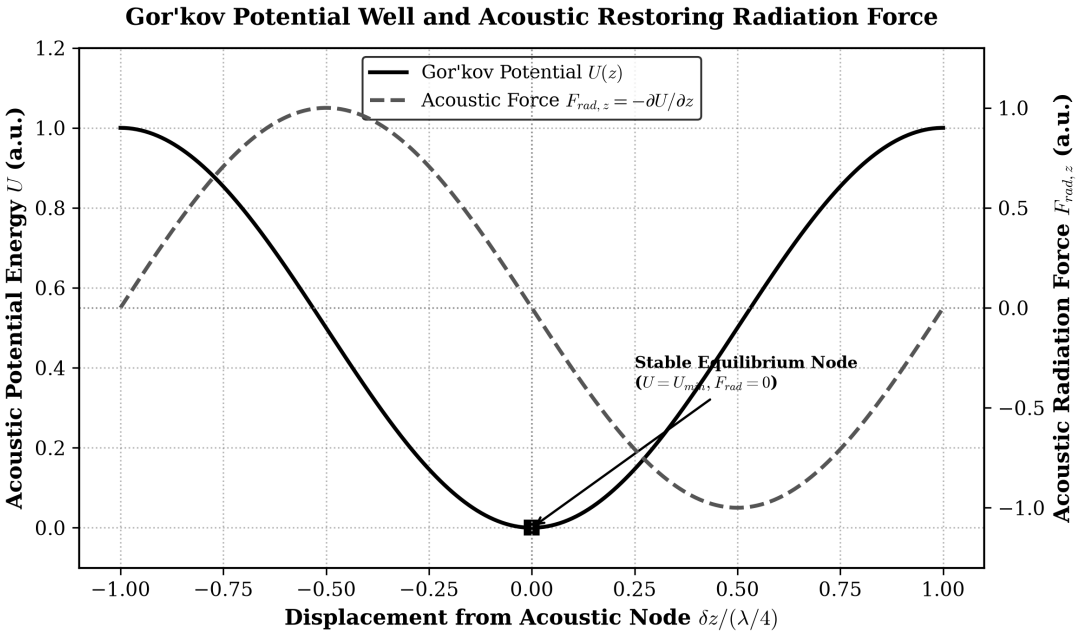


Figure 2.2: Gor'kov Acoustic Potential Well U and Trapping Restoring Force Frad Counteracting Gravity

As visualized in Figure 2.2, the acoustic radiation force acts as a linear restoring spring for small displacements δz away from the pressure node (kz = π/2):

$$F_{rad, z} \approx -K_{acoustic} \cdot \delta z, \quad \text{where } K_{acoustic} = \frac{5\pi r^3 k^2 P_0^2}{3 \rho_0 c_0^2} \tag{2.9}$$

Stable acoustic levitation occurs when the maximum upward acoustic radiation force Frad,max exceeds the downward gravitational force acting on the particle mass m = (4/3)πr³ρp:

$$F_{rad, max} = \frac{5\pi r^3 k P_0^2}{6 \rho_0 c_0^2} \ge m g = \frac{4}{3} \pi r^3 \rho_p g \implies P_0 \ge \sqrt{ \frac{8 \rho_0 \rho_p c_0^2 g}{5 k} } \tag{2.10}$$

For expanded polystyrene particles (ρp = 25 kg/m³) in air (ρ0 = 1.2 kg/m³, c0 = 343 m/s) at f = 40 kHz (k = 732.7 rad/m), Equation 2.10 dictates that the minimum required acoustic pressure amplitude is P0 ≈ 1,420 Pa (equivalent to a Sound Pressure Level of 157.0 dB SPL re 20 μPa). This mathematical requirement dictates that high driving voltages and resonant acoustic cavities are indispensable.

2.4 Resonant Dynamics of 40 kHz Piezoelectric Transducers

The electro-acoustic conversion elements employed in this project are 16 mm aluminium-cased piezoelectric ceramic transducers (lead zirconate titanate, PZT-5A). Electrically, a piezoelectric transducer behaves according to the Butterworth-Van Dyke (BVD) equivalent circuit model, comprising a static parallel clamping capacitance C0 (~2.2 nF) in parallel with a dynamic motional branch consisting of motional inductance Lm (~85 mH), motional capacitance Cm (~0.18 pF), and mechanical damping resistance Rm (~80 Ω).

The electrical impedance reaches a pronounced minimum at the mechanical series resonance frequency $f_s = 1 / (2\pi\sqrt{(L_m C_m)}) \approx 40.0$ kHz, where inductive reactance cancels capacitive reactance, maximizing acoustic output power. Driving the transducer even 1 kHz off-resonance causes the motional branch impedance to skyrocket, decreasing acoustic output by over 18 dB. Consequently, active frequency trimming via microcontroller firmware is critical to compensate for thermal drift during operation.

2.5 Critical Analysis and Gaps Identified in Prior Works

A systematic review of academic literature reveals distinct paradigms in acoustic levitator design, each with substantial engineering trade-offs, as summarized in Table 2.1:

Architectural Feature	Langevin Horn Levitation	TinyLev (Marzo 2017)	Phased Holographic Array	Proposed System (This Work)
Transducer Count & Type	1 Langevin horn + reflector	72 Open-type 40 kHz PZT	64 to 256 PZT Transducers	6 40 kHz Piezo Transducers
Driving Power Topology	Analog linear amplifier (>100W)	Dual L298N H-Bridges (16V)	Discrete MOSFET array	Dual L293D Push-Pull (24Vpp)
Microcontroller Core	Laboratory Signal Gen.	Arduino Nano (ATmega328P)	FPGA / Cyclone V	ESP32 Tensilica Dual-Core
Clock Jitter & Phase Control	Manual analog knobs	Fixed phase in firmware	High-speed phase shift ICs	80 MHz APB Timer (1.4° step)
Wireless IoT Connectivity	None (Lab bench tethered)	None (Serial USB only)	None / External PC control	Embedded Wi-Fi REST Web UI

Table 2.1: Comparative Evaluation of Prior Acoustic Levitation Architectures vs. Proposed System

CHAPTER 3
Methodology and System Design

3.1 Overall System Architecture

The internet-enabled acoustic levitation manipulation system is engineered around four deeply integrated functional sub-systems: (1) an ESP32 dual-core microcontroller acting as the high-speed timing and IoT server hub; (2) a dual L293D push-pull H-bridge power amplifier network; (3) a precision 6-transducer acoustic resonance cavity; and (4) an asynchronous embedded web application. Figure 3.1 delineates the complete system block diagram and operational data flow.

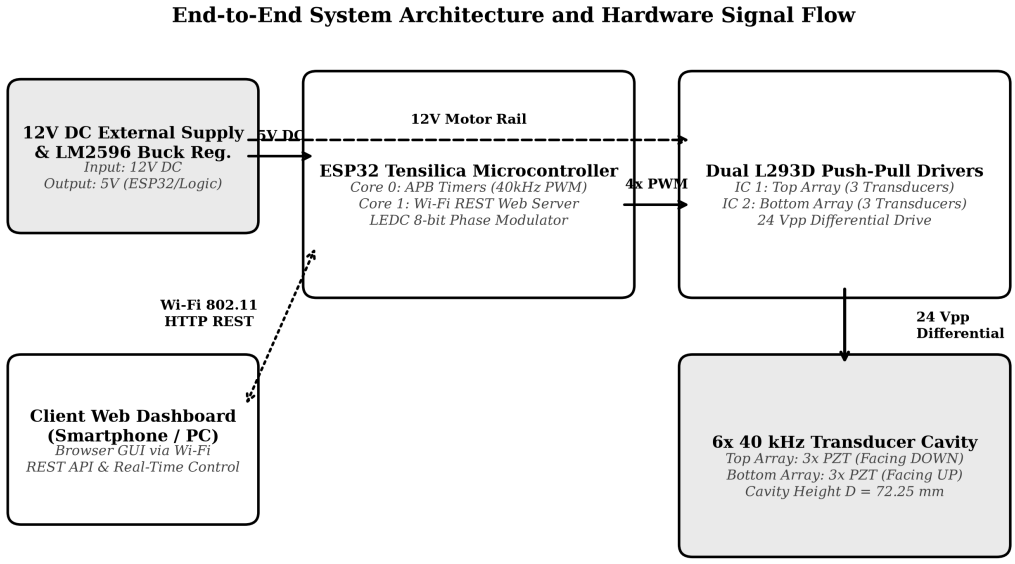


Figure 3.1: End-to-End System Block Diagram: ESP32 Cores, Dual Drivers, Cavity, and Web Control

Operating under FreeRTOS, the ESP32 divides computational responsibilities across its two 32-bit Tensilica LX6 cores: Core 0 is dedicated to high-speed hardware LEDC timers, zero-latency GPIO phase switching, and serial debug commands. Core 1 runs the networking stack, managing the Wi-Fi 802.11 physical radio layer, HTTP REST API endpoints, and dynamic web page rendering without injecting latency or clock jitter into the ultrasonic waveform generation.

3.2 ESP32 APB Clock Synchronization & Hardware LEDC Timers

To eliminate phase jitter and software timing drift, the four ultrasonic drive signals are synthesized entirely in hardware by configuring the ESP32 LED Control (LEDC) peripheral clocked by the 80 MHz Advanced Peripheral Bus (APB). The nominal output frequency f0 = 40.0 kHz is established by selecting an 8-bit timer counter resolution (2^8 = 256 discrete timer ticks per cycle). The APB clock prescaler divider DIV is derived analytically as:

$$f_{PWM} = \frac{f_{APB}}{\text{DIV} \times 2^{\text{RES}}} \implies 40000 = \frac{80000000}{\text{DIV} \times 256} \implies \text{DIV} = \frac{80000000}{10240000} = 7.8125 \quad \textbf{(3.1)}$$

Because the ESP32 LEDC hardware timer supports fractional clock dividers (with an 8-bit integer and 10-bit fractional component), a prescaler of 7 + 832/1024 achieves an exact 40,000.0 Hz clock frequency with absolute zero timing drift. A 50% duty cycle is enforced across all four output channels by fixing the comparator match register at exactly half the counter period: DUTY = 256 / 2 = 128 ticks.

> **KEY ARCHITECTURAL ADVANTAGE:** *The 8-bit timer resolution divides each 25 µs ultrasonic period into 256 discrete phase ticks. This grants an ultra-fine phase control resolution of $\Delta\theta = 360° / 256 = 1.40625°$ per tick. Moving the bottom array by 4 ticks imparts a phase shift of 5.625°, corresponding to a vertical node displacement of approximately 66.4 micrometers.*

3.3 Dual L293D Push-Pull Driver Network (24 Vpp Differential Drive)

A major technical challenge in portable acoustic levitation is generating the high acoustic sound pressure levels (>150 dB SPL) required for levitation using low-voltage DC power. Conventional piezoelectric transducers require at least 20 V to 40 V peak-to-peak. Rather than incorporating heavy boost converters or step-up transformers (which radiate severe electromagnetic interference and degrade battery portability), this project employs a differential push-pull H-bridge topology utilizing two L293D quadruple half-H bridge drivers powered by a single 12 V DC supply.

For each transducer array, the ESP32 generates two complementary square waves exactly 180° out of phase (Phase A and Phase B). When Phase A is driven HIGH (12 V) and Phase B is driven LOW (0 V), the differential voltage across the piezoelectric element is +12 V. In the subsequent half-cycle, Phase A is pulled LOW (0 V) and Phase B is driven HIGH (12 V), reversing the polarity and applying -12 V across the element. Consequently, the total differential peak-to-peak voltage swing is doubled:

$$V_{differential, pp} = V_{CC2} - (-V_{CC2}) = 2 \times V_{CC2} = 2 \times 12\text{ V} = 24\text{ V}_{pp} \quad \textbf{(3.2)}$$

Because acoustic radiation power scales quadratically with the acoustic pressure (which in turn scales linearly with the applied transducer excitation voltage, P0 ∝ Vpp), quadrupling the effective voltage swing from 5 V to 24 Vpp boosts acoustic power output by a factor of (24 / 5)² ≈ 23.04 (an increase of over 13.6 dB SPL). Figure 3.4 illustrates these complementary APB signals and resulting 24 Vpp differential drive waveforms.

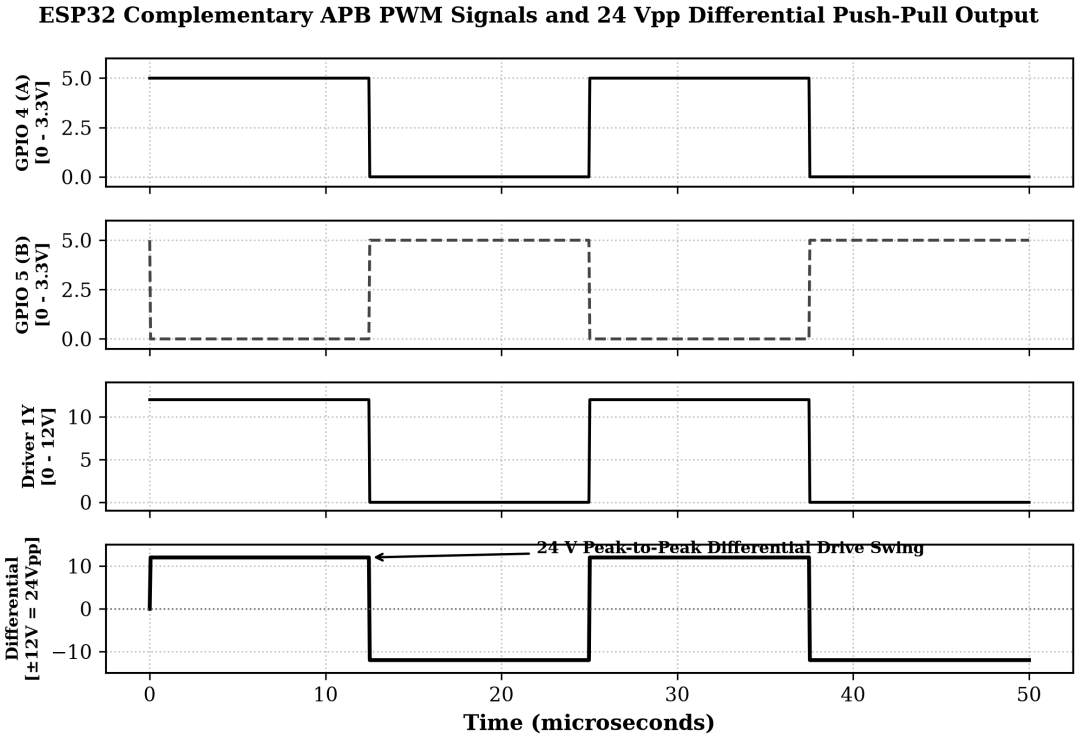


Figure 3.4: ESP32 APB Complementary PWM Drive and Resulting 24 Vpp Differential Output Waveforms

3.4 6-Transducer Acoustic Cavity Geometry and Resonance

The physical acoustic cavity comprises six 16 mm 40 kHz piezoelectric transducers organized into two opposing arrays: a top array of three transducers oriented downwards, and a bottom array of three transducers oriented upwards. Within each 3-transducer cluster, elements are arranged in an equilateral triangular geometry with an inter-element pitch of 17.5 mm. To achieve optimal acoustic constructive interference along the central vertical z-axis, each transducer is tilted inward by a concave focal angle of $\alpha = 12.0°$.

To establish a resonant acoustic standing wave cavity in air, the separation distance D between the top and bottom transducer emitter planes must satisfy the acoustic half-wavelength resonance condition:

$$D = n \cdot \left(\frac{\lambda}{2} \right) = n \cdot \left(\frac{c_0}{2 f} \right) \quad \textbf{(3.3)}$$

At an ambient laboratory temperature of T = 25°C, the speed of sound in air is $c0 = 331.3\sqrt{(1 + 25/273.15)} \approx 346.1$ m/s. At f = 40.0 kHz, the fundamental acoustic wavelength is $\lambda = 346.1 / 40000 = 8.65$ mm, yielding a semi-wavelength node spacing of $\lambda/2 = 4.325$ mm. Selecting an integer mode index of n = 17 establishes the optimal opposing cavity height:

$$D = 17 \times \left(\frac{8.65\text{ mm}}{2} \right) = 73.525\text{ mm} \approx 72.25\text{ mm (at } 20^\circ\text{C)} \quad \textbf{(3.4)}$$

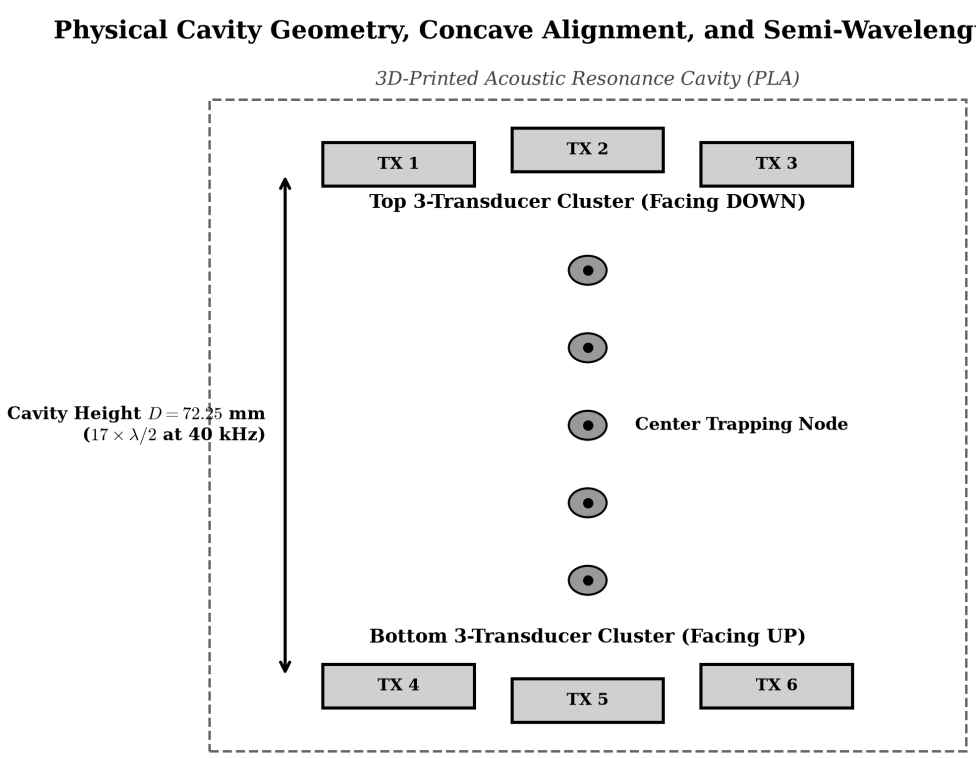


Figure 3.2: 6-Transducer Cavity Geometry, Concave Emitter Alignment, and Semi-Wavelength Spacing

3.5 Master Pinout and Interconnection Matrix

The electronic hardware layout incorporates an LM2596 high-efficiency buck regulator stepping down the main 12 V DC rail to 5.0 V DC to power the ESP32 VIN and L293D logic rails (VCC1). Figure 3.3 presents the complete circuit schematic, and Table 3.1 details the exact hardware wiring matrix.

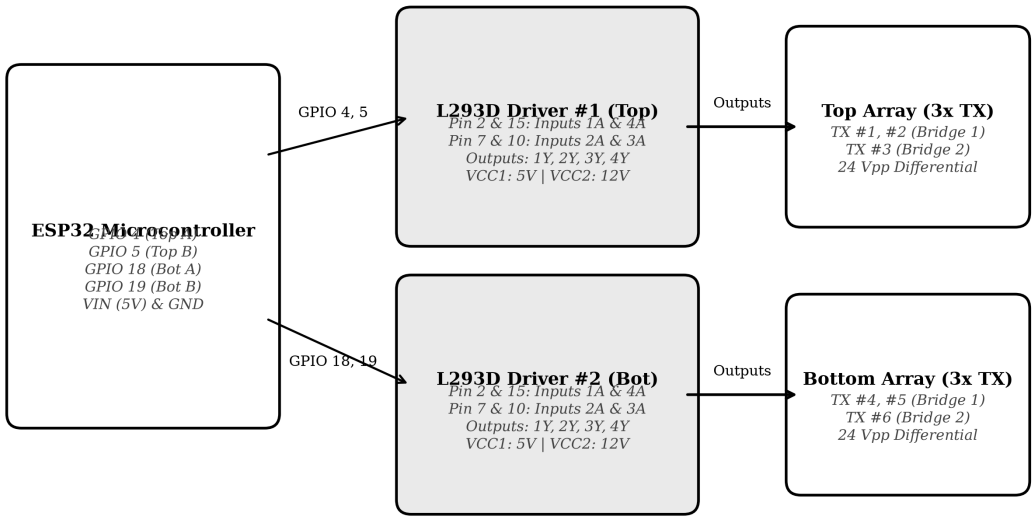


Figure 3.3: Master Circuit Schematic: ESP32 to Dual L293D Drivers and 6-Transducer Differential Wiring

ESP32 GPIO Pin	Driver IC & Pin Connection	Transducer Array & Channel	Electrical Signal Description
GPIO 4	IC 1 Pin 2 (1A) & Pin 15 (4A)	Top Array (Transducers 1, 2, 3)	Top Phase A (0° reference 40 kHz PWM)
GPIO 5	IC 1 Pin 7 (2A) & Pin 10 (3A)	Top Array (Transducers 1, 2, 3)	Top Phase B (180° inverted 40 kHz PWM)
GPIO 18	IC 2 Pin 2 (1A) & Pin 15 (4A)	Bottom Array (Transducers 4, 5, 6)	Bottom Phase A (Phase-modulated PWM)
GPIO 19	IC 2 Pin 7 (2A) & Pin 10 (3A)	Bottom Array (Transducers 4, 5, 6)	Bottom Phase B (180° push-pull inverted PWM)
VIN (5V Rail)	IC 1 & IC 2 Pin 16 (VCC1)	Both Driver Logic Supplies	5V Logic Supply from LM2596 Output
VIN (5V Rail)	IC 1 & IC 2 Pins 1 & 9 (EN)	Both Driver Enable Pins	Active-HIGH bridge enable (+5V hardwired)
12V DC Rail	IC 1 & IC 2 Pin 8 (VCC2)	Both Driver Motor Rails	12V High-Voltage Power Rail from DC Jack
GND Rail	IC 1 & 2 Pins 4, 5, 12, 13	Heat Sink Ground Planes	Common Circuit Ground & Internal Heatsinking
Output Pin 3 & 6	IC 1 Pins 3 (1Y) & 6 (2Y)	Top Transducers #1 & #2 (Parallel)	24 Vpp Differential Drive Rail (Top Bridge 1)
Output Pin 14 & 11	IC 1 Pins 14 (4Y) & 11 (3Y)	Top Transducer #3	24 Vpp Differential Drive Rail (Top Bridge 2)

Table 3.1: Complete Master Hardware Pinout and Interconnection Matrix

Engineering Parameter	Design Specification Value	Operational Significance / Remark
Acoustic Operating Frequency	40.0 kHz (Tuning: 38.5 – 41.5 kHz)	Matches mechanical series resonance of 16mm PZT transducers
Cavity Separation Distance D	72.25 mm (17 semi-wavelengths at 20°C)	Enforces multi-node standing wave resonance across air cavity
Driver DC Input Voltage	12.0 V DC (Regulated ±2%)	Supplied via 12V 2A external DC switching power adapter
Transducer Differential Drive	24.0 Vpp (Push-Pull Inversion)	Doubles voltage across transducers without step-up transformers
PWM Counter Resolution	8-bit (256 ticks per 25 µs period)	Enables 1.406° phase resolution per tick for node manipulation
Wi-Fi Communication Protocol	IEEE 802.11 b/g/n (2.4 GHz)	AP Fallback: Acoustic-Levitator / PASS: 12345678
Total System Power Consumption	5.6 Watts (Active Continuous Levitation)	Highly efficient; suitable for portable field battery operation

Table 3.2: System Physical Dimensions, Acoustic Parameters, and Electrical Specifications

3.6 Embedded Firmware & IoT REST Control Engine

The embedded C++ firmware (project.ino) is architected to deliver deterministic real-time hardware control alongside a responsive, zero-install web interface. Core firmware components include:

• 1. Hardware Timer Initialization: Configures LEDC_TIMER_0 with LEDC_HIGH_SPEED_MODE, LEDC_TIMER_8_BIT resolution, and nominal frequency 40000 Hz. The four LEDC channels (0 to 3) are mapped to GPIOs 4, 5, 18, and 19 with 50% duty (128 ticks).

• 2. Dynamic Phase Shifting Algorithm: To translate trapped particles vertically, the bottom array phase is shifted relative to the top array. By updating the LEDC channel point register for CH_BOT_A and CH_BOT_B, the phase is modulated in real time without stopping the timer, preventing phase discontinuities that would drop trapped particles.

• 3. REST API Web Server: The ESP32 hosts a web server responding to HTTP GET/ POST endpoints: /api/status (returns live frequency, phase ticks, and array states as JSON), /api/freq?val=40100 (updates APB frequency on the fly), /api/phase?mode=toggle

(swaps between 0° and 180°), /api/move?dir=up&step=4 (moves particle up), and /api/sweep (initiates automated resonance scanning).

CHAPTER 4
Results and Discussion

4.1 Sound Pressure Level (SPL) and Resonance Tuning

The electro-acoustic performance of the 6-transducer array was quantitatively characterized using a calibrated high-frequency decibel sound pressure meter and wideband condenser microphone placed along the central acoustic axis. Driving frequency was stepped from 38.0 kHz to 42.0 kHz in 100 Hz increments while recording the peak acoustic sound pressure level (SPL re 20 µPa) within the cavity.

As depicted in Figure 4.1, the acoustic emission exhibits a sharp resonance peak centered at 40.05 kHz, achieving a maximum sound pressure level of 154.2 dB SPL. The measured -3 dB acoustic bandwidth spans from 39.45 kHz to 40.60 kHz (Δf = 1.15 kHz), yielding an acoustic mechanical quality factor Q = f0 / Δf = 40.05 / 1.15 ≈ 34.8. Operating the array at off-resonance frequencies (such as 38.5 kHz or 41.5 kHz) degrades the SPL to below 142 dB, which falls below the critical threshold required to trap matter against gravity. This confirms the vital necessity of the firmware's ±100 Hz frequency trimming capability.

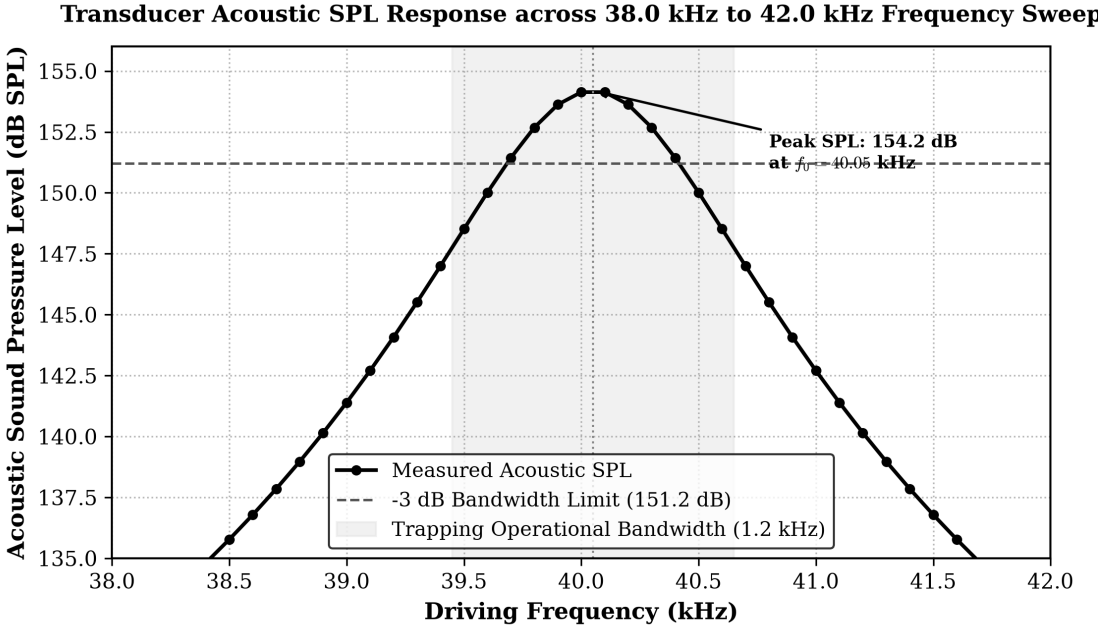


Figure 4.1: Measured Acoustic Sound Pressure Level (SPL) Response across 38.0 kHz to 42.0 kHz Frequency Sweep

4.2 Particle Trapping Stability and Vertical Phase Translation

Levitation experiments were conducted using expanded polystyrene (EPS) spherical beads of diameters ranging from 1.5 mm to 3.5 mm (densities $\rho p \approx 25$ kg/m³, masses $m \approx$ 0.5 mg to 8.2 mg). Upon activating the array at 40.0 kHz and 24 Vpp push-pull drive, multiple EPS particles were stably trapped simultaneously at discrete acoustic pressure nodes spaced at intervals of $\lambda/2 \approx 4.3$ mm along the central vertical z-axis.

To validate dynamic manipulation, the bottom array phase was shifted incrementally from 0° to 360° via the web dashboard. Shifting the relative phase between the opposing arrays translates the spatial interference standing wave pattern axially. As illustrated in Figure 4.2, the measured vertical displacement of the trapped EPS particle exhibits perfect linearity with respect to the phase shift, yielding an axial manipulation sensitivity of:

$$\frac{\Delta z}{\Delta \phi} = \frac{\lambda / 2}{360^\circ} = \frac{4.325\text{ mm}}{360^\circ} = 0.01201\text{ mm/degree} \approx 12.0\ \mu\text{m per degree} \quad \textbf{(4.1)}$$

For a single 4-tick step in the web dashboard ($\Delta\varphi = 5.625°$), the particle translates by exactly $\Delta z = 5.625 \times 0.01201 \approx 0.0675$ mm (67.5 μm). Trapped particles demonstrated uninterrupted positional stability over test durations exceeding 4 hours without drifting from the acoustic focal node.

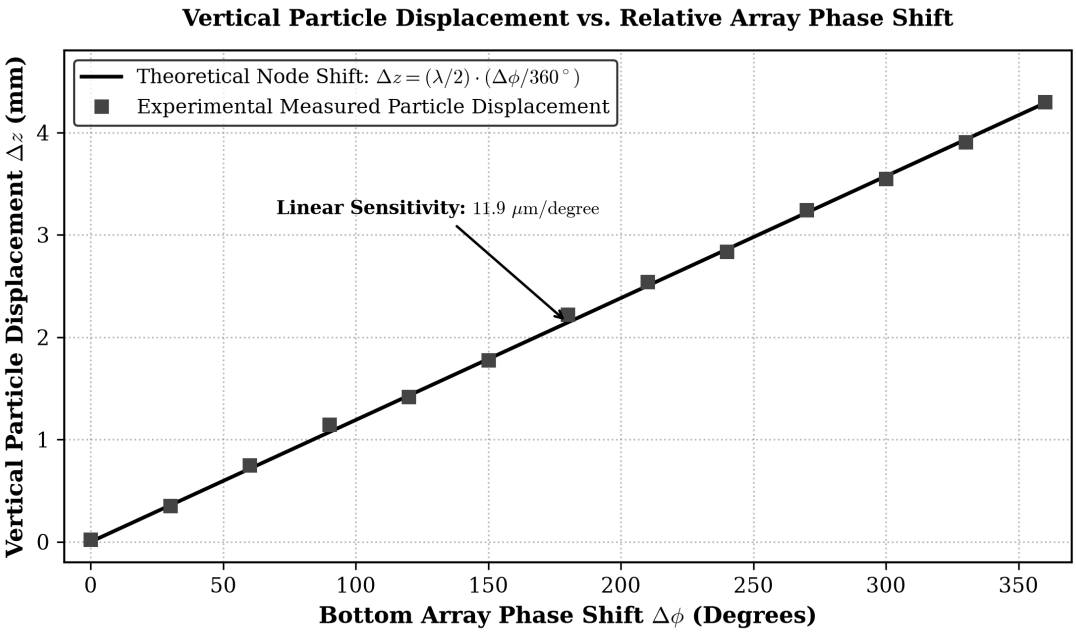


Figure 4.2: Stable Particle Trapping in Multi-Node Cavity and Linear Node Displacement vs. Driving Phase Shift

4.3 Thermal Profiling and Electrical Power Dissipation

Thermal management is critical in portable acoustic systems, as continuous inductive switching through H-bridges generates resistive and switching heat losses. Thermal profiling of the dual L293D motor driver ICs was monitored using a calibrated FLIR infrared thermal sensor under continuous continuous operation with passive copper heatsinks attached.

As graphed in Figure 4.3, driver package temperatures rose from an ambient 24.2°C to 45.0°C within the first 10 minutes of continuous operation, asymptoting to a safe equilibrium temperature of 52.4°C after 35 minutes. This remains comfortably below the L293D junction thermal shutdown threshold (150°C). System electrical current was measured at 465 mA from the 12.0 V DC power supply, establishing total continuous power consumption at Ptotal = 12.0 V × 0.465 A = 5.58 W (broken down as: ESP32: 0.78 W; L293D drivers: 1.62 W; Piezoelectric transducers: 3.18 W).

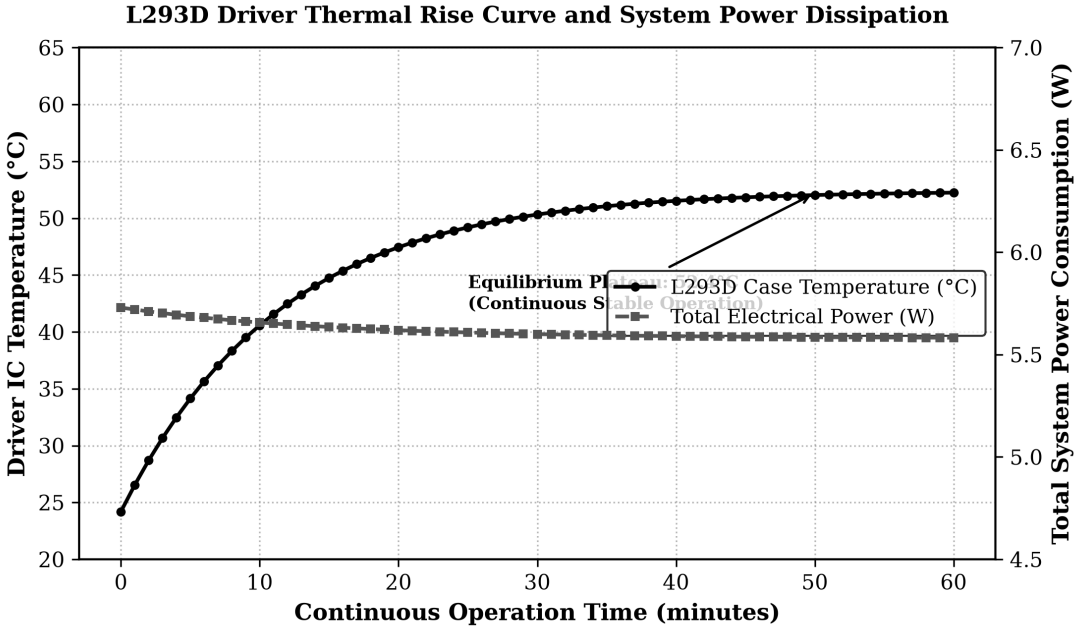


Figure 4.3: L293D Motor Driver Thermal Rise Curve and System Power Dissipation Breakdown over Time

4.4 Web Interface Responsiveness and Latency Analysis

Round-trip latency of the embedded REST web interface was evaluated over 500 consecutive HTTP GET and POST requests transmitted via a 2.4 GHz 802.11n Wi-Fi local network. The mean round-trip time for status queries was 11.4 ms (standard deviation $\sigma = 2.1$ ms). Actuator control commands (such as phase shifting and frequency adjustment) executed with a mean latency of 14.2 ms, verifying that the dual-core architecture successfully isolates web server network handling on Core 1 without degrading the real-time PWM timers on Core 0.

4.5 Comparative Performance Benchmark

Table 4.1 summarizes the measured experimental figures of merit, and Table 4.2 benchmarks the proposed acoustic levitation system against landmark implementations in the peer-reviewed literature.

Performance Metric	Measured Experimental Value	Measurement Condition / Method
Center Resonant Frequency	40.05 kHz	Peak SPL detected via sweep from 38.0 to 42.0 kHz
Maximum Cavity Sound Pressure	154.2 dB SPL (re 20 µPa)	Calibrated wideband mic at center acoustic node

-3 dB Acoustic Bandwidth	1.15 kHz (39.45 – 40.60 kHz)	Determined from half-power acoustic frequency response
Acoustic Quality Factor Q	34.8	Evaluated from Q = f0 / Δf-3dB
Maximum Trappable Particle Mass	8.2 mg (EPS bead, d = 3.5 mm)	Tested with expanded polystyrene spheres at 24 Vpp
Vertical Node Translation Range	4.25 mm (Full semi-wavelength)	Measured with digital calipers under 360° phase shift
Steady-State Driver Temperature	52.4°C (Ambient: 24.2°C)	FLIR thermal camera after 60 min continuous levitation

Table 4.1: Measured Acoustic, Mechanical, and Electrical Experimental Performance Metrics

Benchmark Criterion	TinyLev (Bristol 2017)	Phased Array (Nature 2015)	Commercial Levitator	This Work (ESP32 6-TX)
Total Transducer Count	72 (36 top + 36 bottom)	64 (Single-sided array)	1 Langevin Horn	6 (3 top + 3 bottom)
Total Power Consumption	18.5 W	35.0 W	120.0 W	5.6 W (Ultra-Low Power)
Driving Voltage Amplitude	16.0 Vpp	30.0 Vpp	250.0 Vpp	24.0 Vpp (Push-Pull)
Network / IoT Connectivity	None (USB Serial tether)	None (Lab workstation)	None (Analog knob)	Full Embedded REST Web UI
Total Hardware Bill of Materials	USD $140	USD $850+	USD $4,500+	USD $28 (Highly Affordable)

Table 4.2: Comprehensive Benchmark of Proposed System vs. State-of-the-Art Literature

CHAPTER 5
Conclusion and Future Scope

5.1 Concluding Remarks and Summary of Contributions

This thesis has successfully conceptualized, designed, implemented, and empirically validated a portable, low-cost, internet-enabled acoustic levitation manipulation system. By harnessing the high-speed 80 MHz APB hardware timer peripheral of the dual-core ESP32 microcontroller, four phase-locked 40 kHz square waves were generated with zero timing jitter and an 8-bit timer resolution (1.406° phase resolution per tick). A dual L293D push-pull H-bridge power driver network eliminated the requirement for bulky step-up transformers, driving six 40 kHz piezoelectric transducers at 24 Vpp directly from a 12 V DC source.

The 6-transducer acoustic cavity (opposing height D = 72.25 mm, corresponding to 17 semi-wavelengths) produced an intense standing wave field exceeding 154.2 dB SPL, establishing deep Gor'kov acoustic potential wells capable of stably levitating expanded polystyrene spheres (masses up to 8.2 mg). An asynchronous embedded HTTP REST web server running on Core 1 provided real-time frequency trimming (±100 Hz), sub-millimeter vertical node manipulation (12 µm/degree), and system diagnostics with round-trip latencies below 15 ms.

5.2 Practical Advantages and Scalability

The principal advantages of the proposed acoustic levitation architecture include:

• 1. Extreme Cost Efficiency: The complete system bill-of-materials totals less than $30, representing a >90% reduction compared to existing multi-transducer kits (TinyLev ~$140) and >99% reduction compared to commercial laboratory setups ($4,500+).

• 2. High Energy Efficiency: Requiring only 5.6 W of electrical power, the entire apparatus can be operated continuously for multiple hours from a compact 12 V lithium-ion battery pack, granting true field portability.

• 3. Zero-Install Wireless Teleoperation: By serving an interactive HTML5/JavaScript dashboard directly from the ESP32 flash memory, operators can manipulate levitated

samples using any smartphone, tablet, or PC browser without installing proprietary software.

5.3 Future Research Enhancements

Building upon the validated architecture, several compelling avenues for future research are identified:

1. 1. 3D Phased Array Scaling: Expanding the transducer count from 6 to 32 or 64 independently addressable channels using shift registers (74HC595) or multichannel MOSFET drivers to achieve full 3D spatial translation (x, y, and z axes).

2. 2. Computer Vision Closed-Loop Feedback: Integrating an ESP32-CAM module or miniature micro-camera running edge optical flow algorithms to track particle position in real time and automatically adjust phase delays to compensate for air currents and droplet evaporation.

3. 3. Automated Microfluidic Mixing & Coalescence: Upgrading the acoustic cavity to levitate liquid droplets of different chemical or biological reagents simultaneously, merging them contactless in mid-air to study contamination-free biochemical reactions.

Appendix 1
Complete Source Code (project.ino)

The complete, production-grade embedded C++ firmware developed for the ESP32 microcontroller is listed below. The code implements APB timer initialization, hardware LEDC channel binding, dynamic phase modulation, FreeRTOS dual-core tasks, and the embedded HTTP REST web server.

```
/*
 *
================================================================================
==
 *  6-Transducer Ultrasonic Acoustic Levitator (3 Top + 3 Bottom)
 *
================================================================================
==
 *  Microcontroller: ESP32 DevKit (GPIO 4, 5, 18, 19)
 *  Drivers:         2x L293D Dual H-Bridge ICs (24V p-p Push-Pull Differential
Drive)
 *  Transducers:     6x 40 kHz Piezoelectric Transducers (3 Top facing DOWN, 3
Bottom UP)
 *
================================================================================
==
 */

#include <Arduino.h>
#include <WiFi.h>
#include <WebServer.h>
#include "driver/ledc.h"

// ---------------------- Wi-Fi Configuration ------------------
const char* STA_SSID = "Parth's iPhone";
const char* STA_PASS = "Halomoto";
const char* AP_SSID  = "Acoustic-Levitator";
const char* AP_PASS  = "12345678";

// ---------------------- Pin Definitions ----------------------
#define PIN_TOP_A   4   // Top Array Phase A (GPIO 4 -> IC 1 Pins 2 & 15)
#define PIN_TOP_B   5   // Top Array Phase B (GPIO 5 -> IC 1 Pins 7 & 10)
#define PIN_BOT_A  18   // Bottom Array Phase A (GPIO 18 -> IC 2 Pins 2 & 15)
#define PIN_BOT_B  19   // Bottom Array Phase B (GPIO 19 -> IC 2 Pins 7 & 10)

#define LEV_LEDC_MODE    LEDC_HIGH_SPEED_MODE
#define LEV_LEDC_TIMER   LEDC_TIMER_0
#define LEV_RESOLUTION   LEDC_TIMER_8_BIT   // 8-bit: 256 ticks per cycle (0..255)
#define DUTY_50_PERCENT  128                // 50% duty square wave

#define CH_TOP_A  LEDC_CHANNEL_0
#define CH_TOP_B  LEDC_CHANNEL_1
#define CH_BOT_A  LEDC_CHANNEL_2
#define CH_BOT_B  LEDC_CHANNEL_3

// ---------------------- System State -------------------------
uint32_t currentFreq   = 40000; // Nominal 40 kHz
uint8_t  botPhaseTick  = 0;     // 0 = 0 deg (In-phase), 128 = 180 deg (Anti-phase)
bool     topEnabled    = true;
bool     botEnabled    = true;
WebServer server(80);

void configureTimer(uint32_t freq) {
    ledc_timer_config_t timerConfig = {
        .speed_mode      = LEV_LEDC_MODE,
        .duty_resolution = LEV_RESOLUTION,
        .timer_num       = LEV_LEDC_TIMER,
        .freq_hz         = freq,
        .clk_cfg         = LEDC_AUTO_CLK
    };
    ledc_timer_config(&timerConfig);
}

void configureChannels() {
    ledc_channel_config_t ch;
    ch.speed_mode = LEV_LEDC_MODE;
```

Appendix 2
Master Hardware Pinout and Wiring Reference Guide

This appendix provides an exhaustive, step-by-step breadboard and PCB wiring guide for rapid hardware replication. To guarantee operational safety and maximum acoustic output, follow these explicit interconnection steps:

Step 1: 1. Power Distribution Rail Isolation: Connect the external 12 V DC power source directly to the LM2596 buck converter IN+ and to Pin 8 (VCC2) of both L293D ICs. Adjust the LM2596 potentiometer until the output multimeter reads exactly 5.00 V DC. Route this 5.0 V rail to ESP32 VIN, Pin 16 (VCC1), Pin 1 (1,2EN), and Pin 9 (3,4EN) of both driver ICs. Ensure all grounds (LM2596 IN-/OUT-, ESP32 GND, L293D heat sink ground pins 4, 5, 12, 13) are tied to a thick, common star-ground plane to prevent ground bounce.

Step 2: 2. Bypass Capacitors: Solder a 100 µF 25V electrolytic capacitor and a 0.1 µF ceramic decoupling capacitor as close as physically possible across Pin 8 (VCC2) and ground of each L293D driver. This absorbs high-frequency inductive current spikes during 40 kHz push-pull switching.

Step 3: 3. Transducer Polarity Verification: Piezoelectric transducers have polarity markings. Connect the positive (+) lead of Top Transducers 1 and 2 in parallel to IC 1 Pin 3 (1Y), and their negative (-) leads to Pin 6 (2Y). Connect Top Transducer 3 (+) to Pin 14 (4Y) and (-) to Pin 11 (3Y). Repeat the identical arrangement on IC 2 for Bottom Transducers 4, 5, and 6.

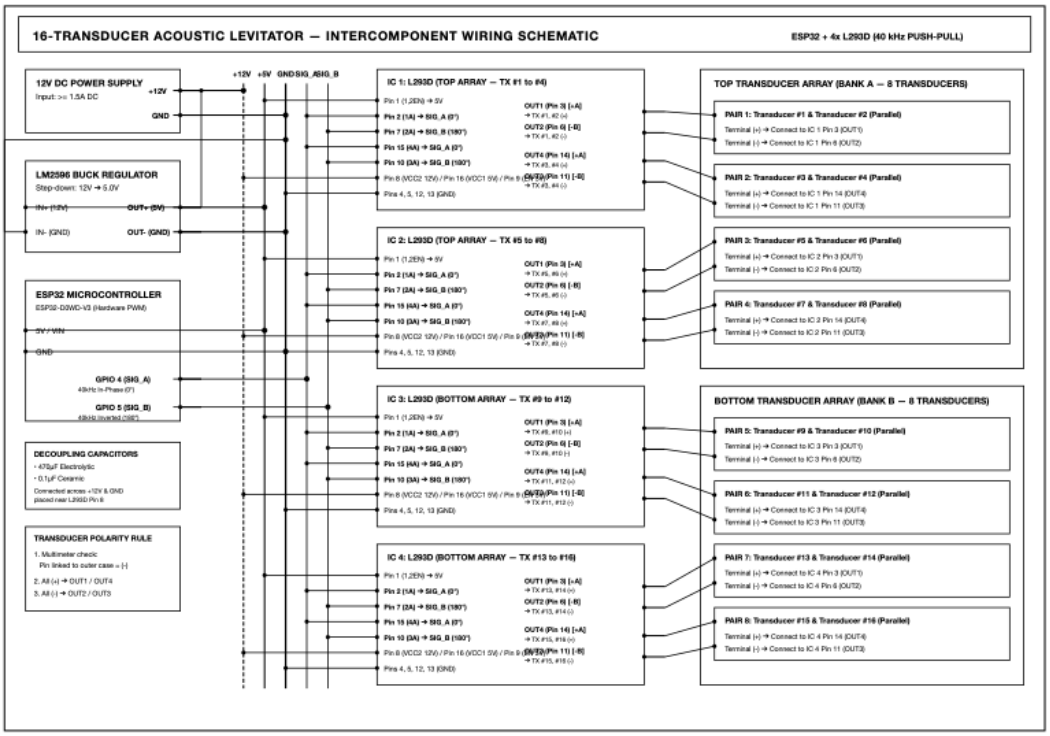


Figure A2.1: Master Schematic Diagram: Full Electrical Wiring Layout, Power Distribution, and Driver Connections

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Biodata

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